LIVIA ZAHARIA / ARTIST PROPOSAL

THE STUMP *OF LIFE*



MATSU / A HUMAN STORY REACHING BACK 8,200 YEARS



Concept sketch; the DNA loop is an explanatory symbol.
Mitochondrial DNA · a record of maternal ancestry

As an artist who also works in science, I was delighted to find an ancient human DNA record from Liangdao, in Matsu. I began imagining a place where someone could simply sit with that long history.

WOOD / A CIRCULAR METAL FACE / A PLACE TO PAUSE

An older *island story.*

The fortifications at Nangan Stronghold 26 made me wonder what had been here before. So I was surprised to find that on Liangdao, in Matsu, researchers had discovered one of Taiwan's oldest human DNA samples. It reaches back 8,200 years.



Liangdao · where the ancient record was found.

The DNA record comes from Daowei I on Liangdao, about 35 kilometres from Stronghold 26. Liangdao Man lived from the sea: his community fished and gathered shellfish. Liangdao is a military islet normally closed to the public. The seat brings an encounter with this ancient life to a former outpost open to visitors.

Photograph: National Museum of Prehistory.
The shell-rich archaeological landscape on Liangdao.



A seat within time.

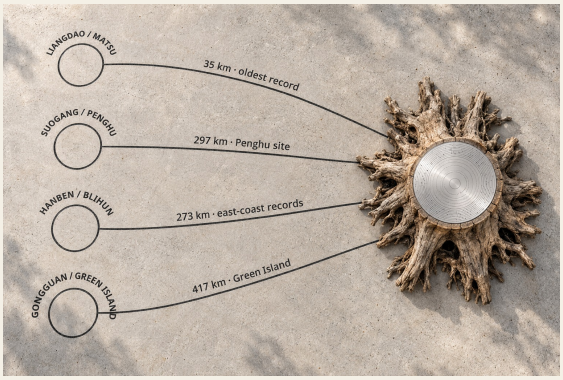


Site photomontage; the exact DNA comparison appears in the appendix.

I looked at the surviving walls, the newer roof and the view of the sea. The place caught my attention. I am an architect, computational designer and jewellery artist. I was pleased to find a subject that brought together my art practice and my work with biological data.

The circular form of this DNA made me think of a tree and its growth rings. What if those rings could be read as the code of life? What if those records could be arranged from older to newer, just like the rings of a tree?

We are also near the sea, where driftwood is common, though large pieces big enough to sit on are rarer. So the proposal is a tree stump at sitting height, with its growth rings marked by a metal plate etched with DNA records. Visitors can look at it curiously, as on a walk among trees and nature, or simply sit down and enjoy the view. From the ends of its former roots, markings on the concrete floor lead towards other places in the region where the samples were found.



Illustrative top view: four places connected by floor lines.



Polished-metal study.

Inside the shelter



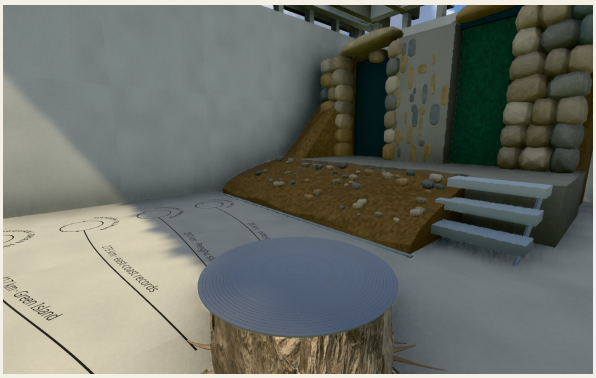
Site photomontage; the proposed position is illustrative and unmeasured.

I would place the work in the lower courtyard on the concrete surface, avoiding the historic part of the surviving fort. It is sheltered from the sun and gives people a space to look closely at the information.

A WALKABLE DIGITAL ISLAND



Livistone screenshot · unmeasured reconstruction.

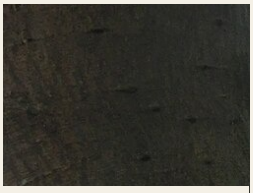


Livistone screenshot · actual DNA surface.

In Livistone, the digital town made from my works, Taiwan becomes an island in the river. Footbridges connect it to a Matsu islet where visitors can explore a digital reconstruction of the courtyard and the stump. It is a virtual version of the physical work. A QR code near the installation will link to it.

Visit: livistone.liviazaharia.com/?place=stump-of-life

Material board



Acacia bark



Chinese elm



WOOD

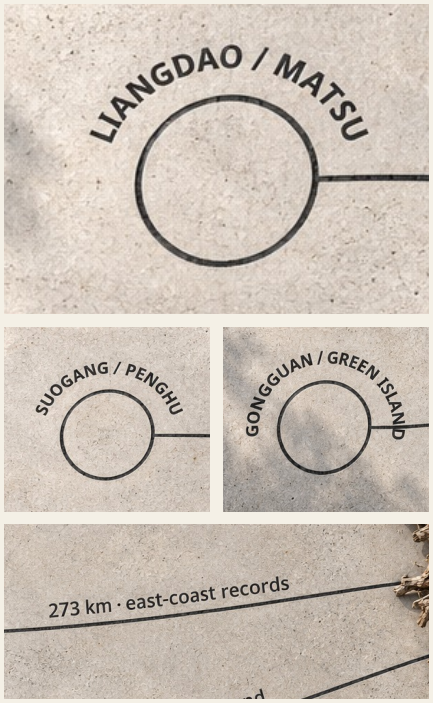
Repurposed wood sourced locally, possibly acacia or Chinese elm. The species will depend on shape, size and availability. No tree will be felted for the project.

I will source a salvaged stump first in Matsu or elsewhere in Taiwan, with the production partner's help, through local arborists or timber yards. The selected piece will be weighed before transport.



STEEL

A solid 316L stainless-steel cap with dark laser engraving and a finished edge. The dark marks stand out against the steel.



FLOOR LINES

Removable stencilled floor lines. The stencil medium will be chosen for removal with water and a soft brush, following a small application-and-removal test on the existing concrete.

Indicative targets, to confirm on the selected stump. Root spread: 1.0–1.2 m. The stump footprint excludes flush floor graphics. The underside will be stable, with fragile root tips trimmed without losing the form.

50 cm
cap / seat height 43–48 cm

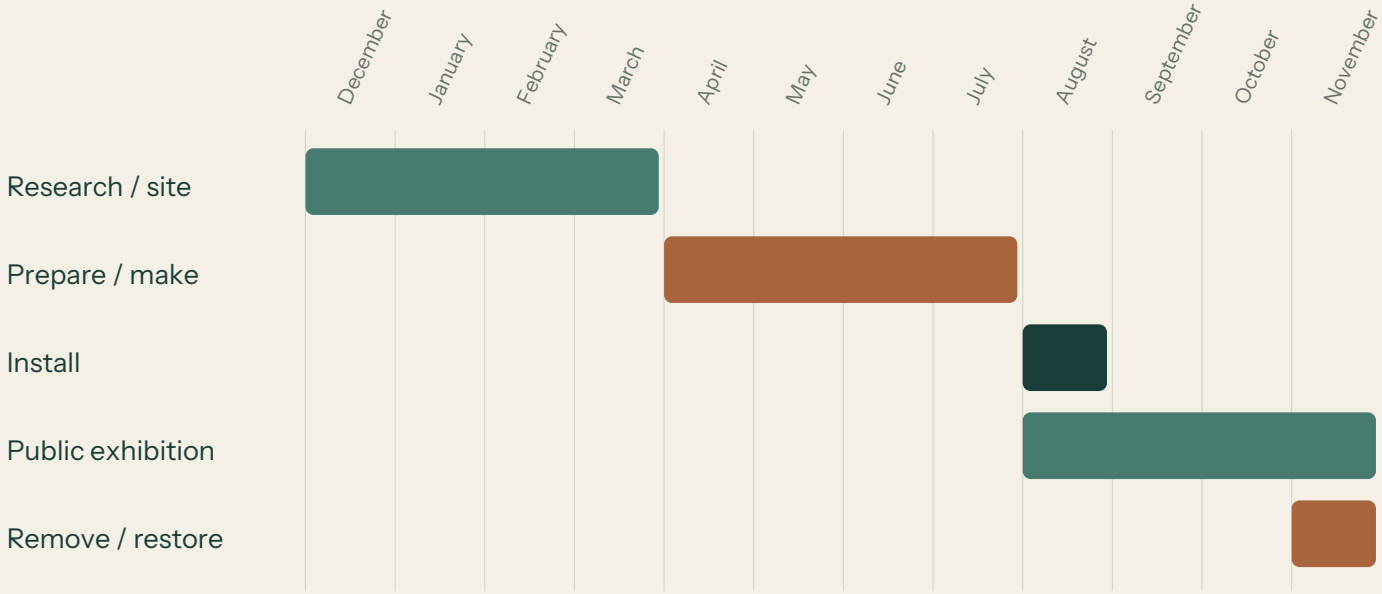
1.2 × 1.2 m
approximate stump footprint

~100 kg
provisional target 80–120 kg

Main wood image: artist-supplied photograph; metal and floor images: illustrative studies. Bark references, cropped: Acacia — Aicsookarm, CC BY-SA 3.0; Chinese elm — Ronnie Nijboer, CC0. Living-tree bark references, not procured timber.

A year to make it.

2026 / 2027



Removal and restoration by 30 November

Confirm the site and review ancient records through March. Prepare the engraving, mounting and floor stencils in April–May; complete material, access and production decisions in June.

25 July

work arrives in Matsu

7–21 August

artist installation / opening visit

10 August

work completed

20 AUGUST – 7 NOVEMBER / PUBLIC EXHIBITION

A local contact receives an illustrated care guide for fixings, timber movement, surface cleaning and floor edges.

ANOTHER LIFE IN MATSU



Possible post-exhibition home · subject to agreement. Official tourism photograph.

I would be happy to give a museum talk during my visit, if a local host arranges the event and local publicity.

After the Biennial, I would like the work to stay in Matsu. I would propose moving the stump and engraved cap to the Matsu Folk Culture Museum on Nangan for continued public use. Placement and care would be agreed with the museum and organiser. The museum already has displays about Liangdao. Stronghold 26 would be restored and the temporary floor markings gently removed. If transfer is not agreed, the wood could become an ordinary bench elsewhere, while any permitted markings fade, like history long passed.

680,000 NT$

A provisional gross request, including artist and research fees, making, travel, care and removal. The actual award and contracting terms remain with the organiser.



- Artist: 120k
- Research: 45k
- Making / public interpretation: 251k
- Travel / stay: 72k
- Logistics / care: 68k
- Tax reserve / contingency: 124k

Artist fee and artistic direction	120,000
Research and fabrication drawings	45,000
Root-flared stump procurement and preparation	120,000
Solid cap, laser engraving and finish	35,000
Samples, mounting and stability review	24,000
Geographic floor graphics: design and fabrication	32,000
Local fabrication and installation help	18,000
Bilingual interpretation and printing	14,000
Visitor interpretation and QR display	8,000
International and Taiwan/Matsu travel	42,000
Accommodation and subsistence, about 14 nights	30,000
Artwork transport and reusable packing	30,000
Artwork and travel insurance	12,000
Exhibition care	10,000
Deinstallation, restoration and local transfer/reuse	16,000
Provisional taxes and remittance reserve	78,000
Contingency	46,000
Total	**680,000**

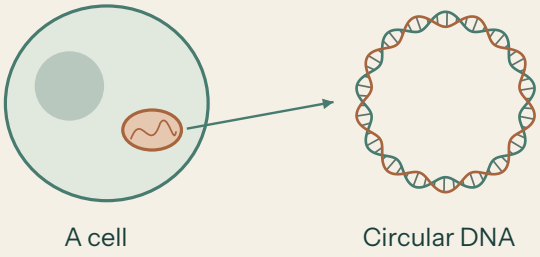
The NT$120,000 timber allowance reflects the cost of a substantial organic root-flared stump. BuyStumps lists examples at US$2,700 / 3,500 / 4,200, before transport, tax and preparation. These are benchmarks, not a confirmed Taiwan purchase or supplier quotation.

The call gives support in principle of NT$800,000; the award is not guaranteed. Tax/remittance and contingency amounts are provisional planning reserves.

How the rings were made.

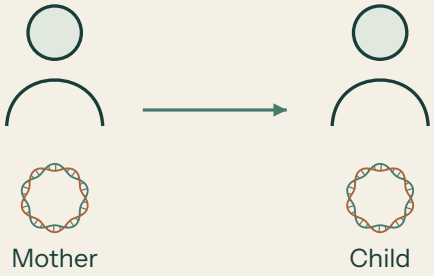
Mitochondrial DNA is a small circle of DNA inside our cells. It usually passes from mother to child and carries a record of one maternal line. It is one part of a person's ancestry.

A SMALL CIRCLE INSIDE OUR CELLS



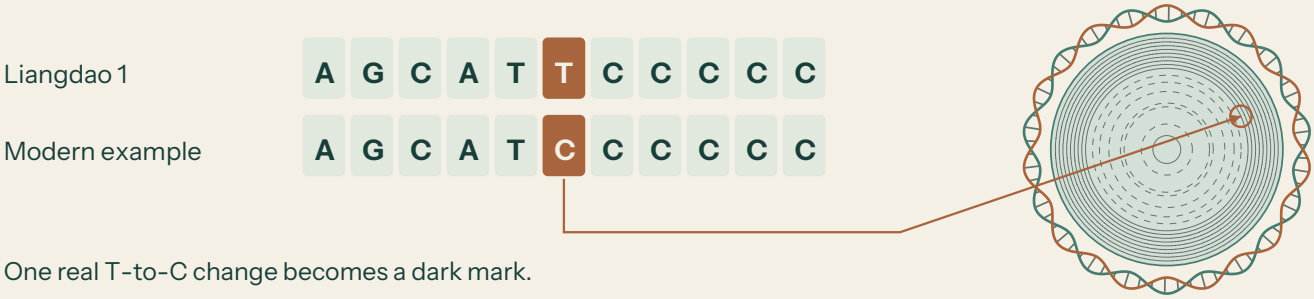
Illustration, not to scale.

A MATERNAL LINE



A general example: usually passed from mother to child.

REAL DNA LETTERS BECOME MARKS



One real T-to-C change becomes a dark mark.

Published DNA, alignment code and mark coordinates can be checked in the repository. The diagrams are drawn in code; Livistone views are screenshots of the working model. AI tools helped develop the illustrative images and software, and edit the text. Source photographs are credited.

With Anton Kulaga, I downloaded published records, aligned the mitochondrial DNA sequences for this prototype and calculated the differences used for its engraved marks. The 16 rings hold the complete Liangdao record, six empty places for ancient records still missing or being checked, and nine modern examples with 294 real marks. Empty rings mean unknown information. Unchanged stretches are compressed. The rings compare records; they do not show a family tree.

The archive contains 550 complete modern records and records for 50 ancient people. Only one ancient DNA circle is complete and published; another 47 records are sets of short DNA fragments awaiting validation. Two Suogang records contain no mitochondrial DNA reads.

My bioinformatics experience includes Just-DNA-Lite and teaching genomics workshops. The public code, source references and figures let anyone check the work.

I use published DNA records with their sources credited, and no human remains or new DNA samples. The rings compare individuals; they do not define a community's identity. I will seek curatorial and relevant community advice on interpretation.

Ko 2014 Larena 2021 Yang 2020 Wang 2021

Code and provenance: github.com/Livia-Zaharia/stump-of-life